baggage, things of all descriptions lying about the streets, besides the bodies of the unfortunate men who had delayed their departure too long, or were too brave to fly and leave their wives and children to our mercy without first sacrificing their own lives in their defence.' He went on:

> I suppose I need not tell you that no males above fourteen years were spared . . . Several were killed before me. Sometimes they were only wounded and were finished by a second ball . . . Some of the men (brutes except in form) wanted to wreak their revenge on the women . . . The greatest part of the merchandise of Kabul and the harems of the principal chiefs had been removed to Istalif on hearing of our advance on the capital, as it had always been deemed impregnable by the Afghans . . . The scene of plunder was dreadful. Every house filled with soldiers, both European and native, and completely gutted. Furniture, clothes, and merchandise of all sorts flung from windows into the streets . . . Some took arms, some jewels, others books . . . When the soldiers had finished the camp followers were let loose into the place, and they completed the business of spoliation . . . All this day the sappers have been employed in burning the town and the soldiers and camp followers in bringing away anything that had been left worth having.

The plight of the innocent women and children of Istalif made an especially strong impression:

> Whilst we were taking the town we saw a poor chubby-faced boy sitting on the side of the road, crying fit to break his heart; the poor little fellow had been deserted or in the hurry left by his parents . . . At one place my eyes were shocked at the sight of a poor woman lying dead, and a little infant of three or four months by her side, but both its little thighs pierced and mangled by a musket ball. The child was conveyed to camp, but death soon put an end to its sufferings. Further on was another women in torture from a wound and she had been exposed to a night without any covering; she clasped a child in her arms, and her affection seemed to be only increased by the agonies she endured . . . Scattered about the streets lay the bodies of old and young, rich and poor . . . As I was returning to camp, sad and disheartened, I saw a poor emaciated old woman who had ventured to leave her hiding place thinking we had left; she was endeavouring to drag herself to a small stream to satisfy her thirst . . . I filled her vessel for her, but all she said was, 'Curses on the Feringhees!' I returned home disgusted with myself, the world and above all my cruel profession. In fact we are nothing but licensed assassins.[91]

From Istalif, the Army of Retribution descended the mountain, and pillaged and burned down the provincial centre of Charikar where Pottinger and Haughton and their Gurkhas had been besieged nearly a year before; as Sultan Mohammad Khan Durrani put it in the *Tarikh-i-Sultani*, 'they set the entire district on fire'.[92] Laden with loot, the Army of Retribution then stumbled back to Kabul.